

Dumpling Fest 2026. Draft for CCM

By Elizabeth Dunlop Richter

The very word “dumpling” conjures up deliciousness. Coziness. Flavor. Home. It doesn’t matter what kind of dumpling because we all have our own favorites. Potstickers. Pierogis. Wontons. And these are just some of the best known of dozens of kinds of dumplings found in virtually every cuisine on earth. A dumpling is simply cooked dough, usually wrapped around a filling, the perfect offering for a festival of cultures, even on a recent damp and cloudy Saturday.



The Chicago Cultural Alliance (CCA) understands the attraction of dumplings. Its 2024 Dumpling Fest attracted over 8,000 hungry participants, delighted to sample a wide range of dumplings from all over the world. This year 18 food vendors filled the northside Wrightwood Park with the tastes and smells of the city’s ethnic neighborhoods for CCA’s two-day 2026 Dumpling Festival. There were ticket presales of over 2,000, a strong beginning.



Dumpling Fest 2026, Wrightwood Park

While satisfying a passion for Chicken Momo, Vegetable Samosa, and Crab Rangoon, the CCA has an ulterior motive for giving Chicagoans a weekend of international taste delights: an appreciation for the cultural richness of Chicago.



Dumpling Fest is just one of the CCA's many programs. An alliance 52 cultural heritage centers and 30 partner museums and organizations from 40 city neighborhoods and 11 Chicago area suburbs representing over 30 different cultures, CCA celebrates diversity, preserves history and honors tradition while supporting cross-cultural collaboration.

The Chicago Cultural Alliance's mission is to connect, promote, and support centers of cultural heritage for a more inclusive Chicago.

The Dumpling Fest features more than dumplings. One of its museum partners, the Kohl Children's Museum in Glenview had a special area for children to explore cultural differences among Chicago neighborhoods. Throughout the day, musical performances entertained diners from the main stage. Returning for a second appearance was the Chicago Garda Pipes and Drums band from the Irish American Heritage Center.



Chicago Garda Pipes and Drums band from the Irish American Heritage Center

Among the many other performers were drummers from the Korean Performing Arts Center, the Latin Music Project Ensemble from the Puerto Rican Arts Alliance, and Friends of the Gamelan's Javanese Ensemble.



Artisans from several cultural groups were also represented. Wila, from Thailand, learned to crochet at age seven. She told Classic Chicago about her dream of opening a flower shop. During the pandemic, she began to crochet a variety of items, including flowers. Her family now helps her build up the inventory of charming, crocheted blossoms among other handmade pieces like key chains, hats, and scarves for her shop, Polmula.



Thai artisan Wila crochets flowers for her shop, Polmula, which means “flower” in the Karen language, spoken in Burma and Thailand.



Polmula crocheted bouquets

In addition to encouraging cultural artistic traditions, CCA provides more practical support to cultural institutions. Programs include Meeting the Moment, a free professional development series focusing on policy, fundraising, the arts landscape, and strategy; capacity building programs; and the Activating Heritage Conference planned for 2027.

More immediately, though, the focus is on dumplings. The participating vendors represent food traditions from Mexico to Poland to Thailand to Japan and all are based in Chicago neighborhoods where people from throughout the world have settled.





Pierogis on the grill





Potstickers warmed on a griddle

Dumpling lovers didn't mind the imminent rain or long lines. When Classic Chicago asked what brought them to the festival, their responses were similar.

"My sister sent me a link, and we love dumplings so we said, 'On this gorgeous rainy day, why wouldn't we want to come here!'"

“I just can’t wait to eat some dumplings and then eat some more dumplings and then a little bit more.”

“Dumplings!”



Long lines did not discourage hungry visitors

Many joined the longest lines even though other lines were shorter. Classic Chicago asked why:

“We thought we might as well check this one out to see if it’s worth the hype.”

“It’s a long line for a reason. It’s got to be the best food.”

“The items they have enticed me...the galbi, a Korean barbecued pork stuffing...”



Everyone had a favorite: “Crab Rangoon” and “Mango Sticky Rice” ... were the favorites at this table.

The international vibe was everywhere, behind the grills, in the food lines, and in the signage, reinforcing awareness of Chicago’s multi-national neighborhoods.







CCA Executive Director Dr. Monica Felix was thankful the rain had stopped, hoping to best the attendance at the 2024 festival. “I’m optimistic...CCA has been around since 2008, and our membership has grown. We had ten founding institutions and now we have a total of about 80...it’s a testament that people want to be a part of this alliance. It’s about the connections and the partnerships that keep forming. The zoo, for example. The Lincoln Park Zoo has been a great partner member. They’ve invited so many of our performing groups to come and perform at the zoo and engage with their audiences.”



CCA Executive Director Dr. Monica Felix had previously been the Museum Director of the DANK Haus German American cultural Center

Felix also reported that the Brookfield Zoo donates about 15,000 tickets to CCA every year, which are in turn given to member families. “We had a great

letter from the Ukrainian National Museum, for example, they were so happy to receive those free tickets. They support a number of immigrant communities who had to flee the Ukraine and are here with their families and want something affordable and fun to do with their families.”

Collaboration, partnership, recognition and appreciation of cultural heritage were among the goals of Dr. Alaka Wali and Dr. Rosa Cabrera, who created the Cultural Connections program at the Field Museum in 1998. This initiative would evolve into a separate 501C3, the Chicago Cultural Alliance in 2008. Eighteen years and six Dumpling Festivals later, the humble dumpling has proven to be a most effective ambassador for the value of multi-cultural collaboration.



Everyone wants a dumpling!

